the work of large-scale enterprises tends to be disrupted by such breaches of "good order" and routine. Not bureaucrats alone but also Presidents have stakes in the effectiveness of the Executive bureaucracy. From any point of view, officials surely are entitled to want White House service in support of their performance.

But if a President should give this service to their satisfaction, what becomes of him? While he sits as the judge of issues brought by others—keeping order, following procedure, filing decisions, clearing dockets—what happens to his personal initiative, his mastery of detail, his search for information, his reach for control? What happens to his own concerns outside the sphere of national security? In short, where is the flexibility he needs to make himself the master of decisions for which he alone remains politically accountable?

To a degree—a large degree—the needs of any President and those of "his" officialdom are incompatible. Rarely can both be served alike. Usually one suffers as the other benefits. The missile crisis seems a rarity in just this sense. But probably it would not seem so had it lasted for another week.[*]

Since World War II our government has often tried to square the circle of this incompatibility by tinkering with structure. Alternately, efforts have been made to tighten up procedures for official consultation and to loosen their constraints upon the White House. Sometimes efforts of both sorts have been made at once, with contradictory consequences. Each Administration has begun by altering the structure it inherited to cure a "weakness" in its predecessor's practice as observed from the outside or from below. The National Security Council, created by act of Congress in 1947, has been called Secretary of Defense James Forrestal's revenge on Franklin Roosevelt for the latter's quite incurable and sometimes costly tendency to keep all threads in his own hands, or anyway in no one else's. The subordinate committee structure Eisenhower later sponsored—the Planning Board and Operations Coordinating Board—was said to be a cure-all for alleged disorder under Truman. Kennedy's abrupt dismantling of that structure was regarded as essential to unleash the human energies locked up inside its "paper mill." Nixon now "restores" a somewhat comparable structure, ending the "excesses" of the Johnson White House, but he ties it to a presidential staff more formidable in numbers and in jurisdiction than his predecessors ever had employed.

So goes the tinkering with structure. None of it thus far has obviated the uncomfortable fact that Presidents rarely are better served than when